

Iceland



Europe's westernmost country was colonized by Vikings and maintains its Scandinavian connection.

874 Iceland is settled by Vikings of Norwegian origin.

930 The Althing, the world's oldest sovereign parliament, is founded.

1262 The independent commonwealth of Iceland declares allegiance to Norway.

1380 Iceland comes under Danish rule when Norway unites with Denmark.

1800 The Althing, which lost influence under Danish rule, ceases to exist.

1814 Norway and Sweden enter a union; Iceland remains Danish.

1843 Althing is reconstituted. When Denmark becomes a constitutional monarchy in 1849, pressure grows for a constitution for Iceland.

1874 Christian IX promulgates Icelandic constitution, granting limited home rule.

1914 Iceland becomes autonomous.

1915 Universal suffrage is introduced.

1918 The Act of Union establishes internal home rule under the Danish crown, which continues to control defense and foreign policy matters.

1940–44 Occupied by UK and US.

1944 Independence as a republic.

1951 US air base built at Keflavík despite strong local opposition.

1972–76 Extends fishing limits to 200 miles (320 km); two "cod wars" with UK.

1985 Declares nuclear-free status.



President Vigdís

In 1980 Vigdís Finnbogadóttir, a former artistic director of the Reykjavík Theater Company, became the world's first elected woman head of state, holding office until 1996.

2008 Financial crisis forces government to nationalize all three major banks. Central banks of Sweden, Norway, and Denmark put in place a 1.5 billion euro package to keep Icelandic economy from collapsing. Interest rates soar to 18 percent and government falls. Social Democrats under Johanna Sigurdardóttir take power.

2009 Iceland applies to join the EU.

2010 Eruption of volcano over the Eyjafjallajökull glacier spreads an ash cloud over Europe, which severely disrupts air traffic for weeks.

Norway



A mountainous country in Scandinavia that was ruled from Denmark for hundreds of years.

800s Norwegians join other Viking groups in seaborne migrations and conquests across Europe and west to Iceland, Greenland, and North America.

872 Harald I Fairhair unifies the small Norwegian kingdoms and proclaims himself king of the Norwegians.

1015–28 Norway becomes Christian under Olaf II.

1396–1814 Under the Union of Kalmar, Danish monarch rules Norway.

1536 Norway is proclaimed a province of Denmark, but retains some traditional institutions. Evangelical Lutheranism is declared the established church.

1814 Personal Union of Danish and Norwegian crowns ends; Norway adopts a new constitution. The Storting (parliament) elects the Danish prince Christian Frederik as king. However, Denmark had ceded Norway to Sweden by the Treaty of Kiel. A brief rebellion led by Christian Frederik is ended by a Swedish invasion; the elderly Carl XIII of Sweden is elected king of Norway. Norway keeps its constitution, parliament, and government.

1905 As tension with Sweden grows, the Storting declares a plebiscite and obtains overwhelming support for independence; Sweden agrees to dissolve the union. Prince Carl of Denmark becomes King Håkon VII of Norway.

1935 Norwegian Labor Party (DNA) forms reforming government.

1942–45 Nazi occupation: Vidkun Quisling leads collaborationist regime.

1945 DNA resumes power.

1949 Founder member of NATO.

1957 King Håkon dies. Succeeded by son, Olaf V.

1960 Becomes member of European Free Trade Area (EFTA).

NORWAY

OVERSEAS TERRITORIES

BOUVET & ST. PETER ISLANDS

Islands in south Atlantic and Pacific oceans.

1739 Discovered by Jean Bouvet de Lozier.

1825 Claimed by Britain.

1930 Dependency of Norway.

1931 Peter I island in far south of Pacific Ocean is made a dependency.

JAN MAYEN

Island in the Greenland Sea.

1614 Dutch whaler Jan Mayen visits and names island.

1921 Norway establishes weather and radio station on this uninhabited island.

1929 Incorporated into Norway.

QUEEN MAUD LAND

Norwegian claim in Antarctica.

1939 Norwegian sovereignty.

1957 Given dependency status.

SVALBARD

Archipelago in the Arctic Ocean.

1194 First discovered by Norsemen.

1596 Rediscovered by the Dutch navigator Willem Barents.

1600s Importance of whale hunting gives rise to rival Dutch, British, and Danish claims to islands.

1920 Spitsbergen Treaty grants sovereignty to Norway but allows treaty signatories to exploit coal deposits.

1962 Unsuccessfully applies to join the European Economic Community (EEC).

1965 DNA electoral defeat by Center Party (SP) coalition led by Per Borten.

1967 Second bid for EEC membership.

1972 EC membership rejected in popular referendum by 3 percent majority. Center coalition government takes power with Lars Korvald as prime minister.

1975 Norway meets UN target of 0.7 percent of GNP in development aid each year, and has done so for every year since then. Aid goes to Africa, South and Central Asia, and now Eastern Europe.

1981 Gro Harlem Brundtland becomes first woman prime minister, but loses power to the first majority Conservative government in 53 years. She regains power in 1986–89 and again in 1990–96.

1985 Norway agrees to suspend commercial whaling, but has since lifted the bans on fishing minke whales and on exporting whale products.

1986 Over 100,000 demonstrate for better working conditions.

1989 USSR agrees to exchange of information after fires on Soviet nuclear submarines off Norwegian coast.

1991 Olaf V dies; he is succeeded by his son, King Harald V.

1993 Oslo accords between Israel and the Palestinians result from secret Norwegian diplomacy.

1994 European Economic Area comes into effect. Referendum rejects EU membership.

2002 Norway acts as peacekeeper in the Sri Lankan civil war.

«202–03 Raiders and Traders

Sweden



An affluent Scandinavian country that was a major European power in the 17th century.

600s The Svear (from which "Sweden" is derived) extend their rule over much of central Sweden.

800s The Svear and Gota ("Goths") join other Viking groups in waves of seaborne migrations and conquest, which extend across Europe and beyond and last until the 11th century.

1100s Christianity becomes the dominant religion throughout Sweden; Erik IX (1150–60) and his successors incorporate Gotland island into the kingdom, which by this stage covers most of present-day southern Sweden.

1319–64 Under Magnus II Sweden establishes control over Finland and Norway, but loses Gotland in 1361.

1396 Union of Kalmar: Sweden and Denmark are joined in personal union under Queen Margrethe I of Denmark.

1523 With tension between Sweden and Denmark growing, the Swedish estates elect a local noble, Gustav Vasa, as king, dissolving the Union of Kalmar.

1527 Evangelical Lutheranism is established as the state religion.

1560–95 Sweden gains Lapland and northern Finland.

1561 Sweden gains Estonia, acquiring Karelia, Ingria, and Livonia (Latvia) by 1629.

1611 During the reign of Gustavus II Adolphus (1611–32) Sweden takes an active part in the 30 Years War (1618–48) and becomes the dominant regional power and a major European power. In 1632 Gustavus II Adolphus is mortally wounded at the battle of Lützen, near Leipzig, although Sweden is victorious.

1632 Gustavus II Adolphus is succeeded by his six-year-old daughter Kristina. His chancellor, Axel Oxenstierna, continues to manage affairs of state during her minority. She is an enthusiastic patron of the arts and the Swedish court attracts some of the best minds in Europe. Having converted to Catholicism, she abdicates in 1654 and dies in Rome in 1689.